

The History of Fanfiction

A brief walkthrough of fanworks by 

I. What is fanfiction?

Fanfiction is a form of creative writing in which fans create their own stories using characters, settings, or ideas from already existing works.

II. What came before?

While fanfiction is often associated with the internet today, its history stretches back much further. For centuries, writers have borrowed from and expanded upon popular stories to create new interpretations of familiar characters and worlds.

Some of the earliest examples of fanfiction can be found in ancient mythology and folklore. It can be seen across different time periods and cultures. Stories about King Arthur were continually rewritten and expanded by different authors over generations. Different medieval writers kept adding new characters and romances and adventures. Lancelot wasn't even introduced in the earliest Arthurian tales.

Another example is Virgil's *Aeneid*, in which Virgil took a character from Homer's epics to write an entirely new story that follows Aeneas after the events of the Trojan War. People jokingly describe this as one of history's earliest examples of "fanfiction," but it really can be looked at it this way.

This can also be seen in older 'unauthorized sequels,' just like we see today. It is common practice in modern fanfiction to continue a story either before the creator does or if the decide not to, and there actually is an unauthorized *Don Quixote* sequel. The *Second Book of the Ingenious Knight Don Quixote of La Mancha* was published by an anonymous author, which Cervantes was unhappy about, but this is a prime example of the type of thing we see today.

The same story plays out over and over. There are so many examples throughout space and time—people rewriting or continuing Shakespeare's plays, amateur writers fixing endings they didn't agree with, so on and so forth.

III. The Rise of Organized Fandom

There was a point when people went from individually enjoying stories to forming communities that actively created and shared art, somewhere around the 30's, fully picking up as time went on. It started with science fiction novel fans and magazines writing letters to each other, to forming clubs, to the birth of the zine.

A zine is a fan magazine that contains essays, artwork, discussions, and more recently, fan-created stories. This was how fandoms operated before the internet was popularized. Back then, zines were typed, copied, and mailed between fans, making it so that fans could share their work and build friendships across long distances.



The Comet, thought to be the first, if not one of the first fanzines we've seen.

The real pioneers of all of this, really, were the Star Trek fans. When the original Star Trek aired, fans became incredibly active, and after it was cancelled, Star Trek zines were the *thing* for publishing functions. A lot of people consider this the birth of modern fanfiction culture as it moved a small side hobby to this major activity.

Things continued to move from there, fans meeting in person at

science fiction conventions where they could exchange stories, artwork, and ideas. Communities were able to develop straight into the age of the internet, only growing from here.

IV. The Era of the Internet

The growth of home internet made it so much easier for fans to connect. People could gather on message boards, forums, mailing lists, and Usenet groups. Fanzines had declined as a result, but fanfiction went from something that had to be printed and mailed to something that could be shared instantly, becoming that much more accessible to both readers and writers.

This, of course, spurred dedicated fanfiction websites, one of them notably being FanFiction.net, which came around in 1998. Readers could search stories by fandom, genre, and characters, and writers could receive feedback through reviews and comments.

Over time, fandom communities continued to grow because we were no longer limited by geography and postal systems. This, however, came with the problems that popularity often brings.

Some authors and creators of original works welcomed fanfiction, however, there were others, Anne Rice, for example, whose name I am putting in very small font, lest she smell I was talking about her and I get a cease and desist, were very opposed to it. Legal teams sent cease and

desists demanding that fanfiction be removed from websites which opened up a whole can of worms legally for fandom communities.

FF-net itself became a bit of a nightmare for people using the platform. Stories based on *certain authors'* works were banned from the archive, creative works could just disappear without warning, there were content bans and story purgers which left fans wanting an archive controlled by fans themselves that didn't allow censorship.

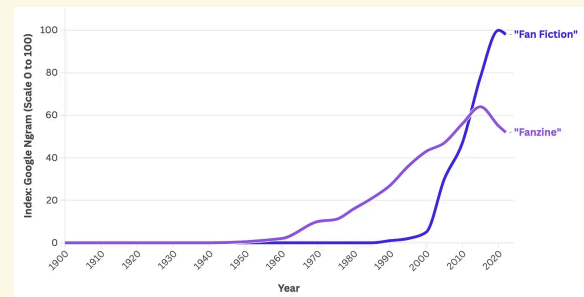
This led to the birth of Archive of Our Own (AO3) in 2008. AO3 was designed to preserve fanworks and allow a full range of fanworks compared to other archives, allowing artists to host stories that were controversial or considered to be too mature. I'm trying my hardest not to get into censorship as this essay will be ten years long, but the point is, censorship is bad and the people who created AO3 stood by that and continue to stand by it today, which is why AO3 is one of the largest and most influential fanfiction archives in the world.

As of now, there are millions of fanfictions published online. It exists for books, movies, TV, games, podcasts, and pretty much any other form of media you can think of. It's a space for creativity where fans can explore different characters and storylines.

It's a place where people can find themselves represented or explore themes safely in the bounds of fiction.

V. Conclusion

Seen below is an example of how the terms 'fanfiction' and 'fanzine' have increased in literature over time measured by Google Ngram, and it shows the history I've relayed above.



Use of "Fanfiction" and "Fanzine" in literature over time using Google Ngram Index.

Although the term fanfiction is relatively modern, the practice of expanding and reimagining existing stories has been going on for centuries. We have watched this practice evolve so much, and it still remains an important form of creative expression that allows fans to participate directly in the stories that inspire them. My hope is it will continue to be this way for a long time.